officer always jumps first, so in my helicopter, I was the first person closest to the ramp to the rear of the helicopter on the port side, which meant that I was the last to board the aircraft. For jumps, the clamshell doors at the rear of the aircraft are removed, so during the take-off and transit, one can see the countryside below. I had a spectacular view since I was right at the edge. Approaching the DZ, the red warning light came on, one minute to DZ, and we all lumbered to our feet facing the rear of the helicopter and hooking up our ripcords to the static line in the helicopter. The light changed; GREEN ON – GO came the order and I jumped (or was I pushed?) out of the helicopter assisted by the para instructor. 'One thousand, two thousand, three thousand, four thousand, five thousand . . . CANOPY', I shouted as taught, looking up to check that the parachute canopy had fully deployed, to the sound of the receding chopper blades. After that was blissful silence, with only the sound of the wind in my ears and the serene sight of the other parachutes floating gently down.

There is a sign in the PTS that reads, 'You can jump from thousands of feet, but it is the last inch that hurts.' That last inch was rushing up to me, or rather the other way around, at an alarming speed. I tried to remember all that I had been taught: ankles and knees tightly together, hands straight up holding the risers, palms facing forward, chin tucked in, the direction of the wind and whether to do a front right or front left roll and . . . WHAM. I hit the ground with a resounding thud, and the roll I did must surely not have been part of any manual. I also had a sharp pain in my right knee and I thought to myself, 'Boy, this is it, first and last jump.' I got to my feet, collected the chute and limped back to the RV, handing in the main and reserve before joining my wife and kids at the grandstand, where Veena was happy to see me back on terra firma. With my jump out of

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